



CUBA

Capital city: Havana
Area: 42,803 sq miles (110,860 sq km)
Population: 11,300,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 41%, other 59%
Government: One-party state
Currency: Cuban peso
Adult literacy rate: 97%
Life expectancy: 77 years
People per doctor: 189
Televisions: 239 per 1,000 people

Cigars are stored in boxes made from cedar wood to keep them fresh.



A good cigar is made from at least five different types of tobacco.

CUBA

MORE THAN 200 RIVERS wind their way across Cuba, watering the lush green scenery of the Caribbean's largest island. The land is made up of mountains, rolling hills, and flat plains, all covered in a fertile soil that is ideal for growing sugar, tobacco, and a variety of tropical fruits and vegetables. Most Cubans are descended from the early Spanish settlers, or from Africans brought over later to work as slaves on the plantations. In recent decades, the socialist policies of the long-standing leader Fidel Castro have kept Cuba isolated from much of the world.



CUBAN POLITICS

In 1959, Fidel Castro and a group of rebels overthrew the ruling dictator, Fulgencio Batista. Since then, Cuba has been a communist state, aided by the Soviet Union until its breakup in 1991. Many of Castro's social policies have been successful. Housing and health care have greatly improved, and most people can now read and write. However, the US remains hostile to the communist government.

CUBAN CIGARS

Cuba's warm days and cool nights are ideal for growing tobacco. Tobacco leaves are picked when pale green and hung up to dry for 40–45 days.

They are then sorted and packed for the fermentation process, which mellows the flavor of the leaf before it is sent to one of Cuba's famous cigar factories. Cigars are rolled by hand by men and women working at long wooden tables.



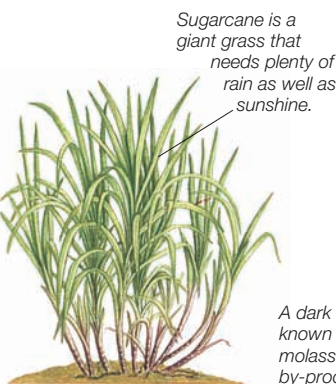
HAVANA

The largest city in the Caribbean, Cuba's capital, Havana, has a population of more than 2 million. It was founded by the Spanish in 1515 and some areas of the city are extremely old, with cobbled streets and elegant colonial buildings. Today, parts of Havana have become run down and in need of improvement. However, housing policies mean there are no shantytowns around the city. Havana is a major port and exports most of Cuba's sugar, tobacco, and tropical fruit.



MUSIC AND DANCE

Cuba's lively music reflects its mix of Spanish and African influences. The Spanish brought distinctive melodies, along with the guitar and violin, and the Africans brought a very different style, as well as various drums and short wooden sticks called claves. The music has gradually fused to create rhythms such as the mambo and salsa. A thriving Afro-Cuban jazz scene has also developed.



SUGAR INDUSTRY

Sugar has long been important to Cuba and still makes up 75 percent of the country's earnings from exports. By the 1800s, the sugar industry was already booming, fueled by African slaves who worked by hand on the vast colonial plantations. Today, the methods are more modern and the cane is usually cut down by machine or bulldozer. However, the collapse of the Soviet Union led to a steep decline in demand for sugar, and reduced supplies of imported oil. To overcome this crisis, many of the mills started to use *bagasse*, a by-product of sugarcane, to run their machinery.

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